

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Extreme Ultra-Density Draft: Chapters 13 & 14 (Redux)

CHAPTER 13: WITNESS: THE NEUROLOGIST

The courtroom smelled of wet wool, floor wax, and the stale heat of bodies packed too closely together. The rain hammered against the windows, a dull, rhythmic thudding that sounded like a heartbeat.

Thump. Thump. Thump.

It was the third day of the trial. The novelty had worn off for the jury. They were no longer looking around the room with wide eyes. They were slumped in their chairs, bored, tired, and looking for a narrative.

They wanted a hero. They wanted a villain.

And Dr. Vogel was auditioning for the role of the Hero.

He sat on the witness stand like a king on a throne. He was a small man, but he occupied space with the confidence of someone who has never been wrong in his life. He wore a tweed jacket with leather patches on the elbows, a sartorial choice that screamed "Ivy League Intellectual" and "Trust Me, I'm a Doctor." He adjusted his thick glasses and looked at the jury with a benevolent, paternal smile.

Owen Thomas stood at the podium. He looked like a general surveying a battlefield he had already won.

"Dr. Vogel," Owen said, his voice deep and reassuring. "Could you state your credentials for the court?"

"I am the Chief of Neurology at the University Medical Center. I hold a PhD in Neuroscience from Johns Hopkins and an MD from Harvard. I have published over forty papers on epileptic disorders."

"So, you're an expert?"

Vogel smiled modestly. "I have dedicated my life to the study of the brain."

"Can you explain to the jury what Temporal Lobe Epilepsy is?"

"Certainly," Vogel said. He turned to the jury, treating them like a classroom of first-year med students. "The brain runs on electricity. It is a biological machine. Neurons fire in a specific sequence, like a symphony. In epilepsy, that symphony becomes a cacophony. A storm. The electrical activity spikes uncontrollably."

He held up his hands, interlacing his fingers to mimic a neural network.

"And the symptoms?" Owen asked.

"They vary depending on where the storm hits. In the Temporal Lobe—the part of the brain that handles memory, emotion, and auditory processing—the symptoms can be... exotic."

"Exotic?"

"Yes. Visual hallucinations. Hearing voices. A sense of 'presence'. And often, a feeling of intense religious ecstasy or terror. We call it *Geschwind Syndrome*."

Juror 4 (The Mechanic) leaned forward. He understood engines. He understood short circuits. This made sense to him.

Owen nodded. He walked to the exhibit table and picked up the chart of Emily's EEG.

"And you diagnosed Emily Rose with this condition?"

"I did. The EEG confirmed it. She had a focus of epileptic activity in her left temporal lobe. A jagged spike of electricity that corresponded exactly with her 'visions'."

"And is this condition treatable?"

"Highly treatable. With medication—specifically Gambrolic—we can dampen the electrical spikes. We can stop the storm."

"So," Owen said, leaning in, his voice dropping to a whisper, "if Emily had continued her medication... would she be alive today?"

Vogel didn't hesitate.

"In my expert medical opinion... yes. Without question. The medication would have controlled the seizures. She would have been able to eat. She would have lived a normal life."

Owen let the silence hang in the room. It was heavy. Damning.

He looked at Father Moore. Moore sat like a stone, staring at his hands.

"Thank you, Doctor," Owen said softly. "Your witness."

Erin stood up.

She felt the eyes of the jury on her. They were hostile. Vogel had given them a simple, clean story. *Sickness + Medicine = Life. Sickness + Religion = Death.*

She had to break that story. She had to take their safe, scientific world and smash it.

She walked to the podium. She didn't smile. She didn't look friendly. She looked like a surgeon picking up a scalpel.

"Dr. Vogel," Erin said. "You stated that Gambrolis is a highly effective treatment."

"It is."

"Did it work for Emily?"

Vogel blinked. "Excuse me?"

"Did the medication work? Did the seizures stop?"

"Well," Vogel shifted in his seat. The wood creaked. "It takes time to titrate the dose. We started her on 200mg."

"And did she report that the visions stopped?"

"She reported... continued episodes."

"She reported that they got *worse*, didn't she?"

Vogel sighed. "Subjective reporting from a psychotic patient is notoriously unreliable, Ms. Bruner. The brain creates narratives to explain the random firing of neurons."

Erin picked up a document from her table.

"This is the nursing log from the hospital. Dated November 14th. Three days after she started the medication."

She read from the page.

"Patient screaming. Restraints applied. Patient claims the 'shadows are heavier'. Patient claims the medicine is 'locking them in'."

Erin looked up.

"Locking them in. Does that sound like a cure to you, Doctor?"

"It sounds like a delusion," Vogel snapped. "Which is a symptom of the disease."

"Is it possible," Erin asked, walking closer to the witness stand, "that the medication paralyzed her body... stopped the convulsions... but did nothing to stop the *experience*?"

"The experience *is* the convulsion, Ms. Bruner. They are the same thing."

"Are they?"

Erin turned to the jury.

"Dr. Vogel, are you familiar with the term 'Chemical Straitjacket'?"

"That is a pejorative term."

"It refers to using drugs to sedate a patient so they are manageable, rather than treating the root cause. Isn't that what you did? You paralyzed her so she couldn't scream? You locked her in a room with her demons and took away her ability to fight back?"

"I treated a medical condition!" Vogel's face was flushing red. "I tried to save her life!"

"You treated a *chart*," Erin said, her voice cutting like a whip. "You treated an EEG readout. Did you ever listen to *her*?"

"I listened to her symptoms."

"Did you listen to what she said the voices were saying?"

"The content of a hallucination is irrelevant. It's just noise. It's static."

"Is it?"

Erin walked to the defense table. She picked up a cassette tape.

"We have a recording of one of these 'hallucinations'. Would you like to hear it? Would you like to hear the 'noise'?"

Owen Thomas jumped up. "Objection! Prejudicial! This is theatrics, Your Honor. The jury doesn't need to hear a recording of a psychotic break to understand the medical facts."

"It goes to the nature of the condition, Your Honor," Erin argued. "The doctor claims the content is random noise. If the tape shows structure, intent, and knowledge... it impeaches his diagnosis."

Judge Brewster looked at the tape. Then at Vogel.

"I'll allow it. But keep it brief."

Erin put the tape in the player. She pressed play.

Hiss. Static.

Then, Emily's voice. But it wasn't Emily.

It was a guttural, wet sound. Like gravel grinding in a meat grinder.

"...I am the dweller in the threshold..."

The jury recoiled. Juror 11 (The Nurse) covered her mouth. Juror 8 (The Student) stopped reading his book.

The voice on the tape shifted. It became high, shrieking.

"...bind me... burn me... I am the fire..."

Then, a third voice. Cold. Arrogant.

"...Doc-tor... Vo-gel..."

Vogel froze. His eyes went wide behind his glasses. His mouth opened slightly.

The voice on the tape laughed. A dry, scratching sound.

"...he thinks he sees... but he is blind..."

Erin pressed stop.

The silence in the courtroom was deafening. It was a vacuum.

Erin looked at Vogel. He was pale. His hands were shaking.

"That was recorded two weeks *after* she started your medication, Doctor. Does that sound like a random firing of neurons to you? Does that sound like 'noise'?"

Vogel licked his lips. "It... it's vocal cord paralysis. A side effect of the..."

"It called you by name," Erin whispered.

She leaned in.

"How did a random electrical storm know your name, Doctor? How did it know you were 'blind'?"

Vogel didn't answer. He stared at the tape player as if it were a bomb.

"No further questions," Erin said.

"Redirect?" Judge Brewster asked.

Owen Thomas stood up. He looked calm, but Erin could see the tension in his jaw.

"Dr. Vogel," Owen said. "Is it possible that Emily heard your name while she was in the hospital? Perhaps from a nurse?"

Vogel grasped the lifeline. "Yes. Yes, of course. She heard the nurses calling me. It lodged in her subconscious."

"So, the 'voice' knowing your name is not supernatural. It's just memory."

"Exactly. Just memory."

Owen sat down.

It was a good save.

But Erin looked at the jury.

They weren't looking at Owen. They weren't looking at Vogel.

They were looking at the tape player.

They were remembering the *sound* of that voice.

It didn't sound like memory.

It sounded like something that had crawled up from the bottom of a well.

[SIDEBAR]

"I want that tape admitted into evidence," Erin whispered at the bench.

"It's highly prejudicial," Owen argued. "It's terrifying the jury. It's emotional manipulation."

"It's the only evidence we have of what was actually happening to her," Erin said. "If the prosecution can show autopsy photos of her starved body to shock the jury, I can play the tape of her soul being torn apart."

Judge Brewster sighed. He looked tired.

"I'll admit the tape," he said. "But be careful, Ms. Bruner. If you turn this courtroom into a haunted house, I will declare a mistrial."

"I'm not trying to scare them, Your Honor," Erin said. "I'm trying to show them the truth."

"The truth," Brewster muttered. "God save us from the truth."

Erin walked back to her table.

She looked at Moore.

"We got the tape in," she whispered.

Moore didn't smile.

"They heard it," he said. "But did they listen?"

"They listened."

"Good," Moore said. "Because once you hear it... you can never unhear it."

Erin looked at Juror 11.

The nurse was rubbing her rosary beads. fast.

Rub. Rub. Rub.

She had heard it.

And she was praying.

Erin felt a chill.

Maybe I should be praying too, she thought.

But she didn't know the words.

So she just opened her notebook and wrote:

THE WALL IS CRACKING.

CHAPTER 14: EMILY: THE SPIRAL

Flashback. December 1976.

The pills were orange.

Small, oval, innocent-looking things.

Gambrolic. 200mg.

Emily held the bottle in her hand. It rattled. *Ch-ch-ch.*

It sounded like a rattlesnake. Or a baby rattle made of bones.

She was back in her dorm room. The university had let her return, "pending stabilization."

Stabilization.

That's what they called it.

Emily called it "The Fog."

She took the pill. She swallowed it dry. It tasted of chalk and chemical bitterness. It scraped down her throat.

Within twenty minutes, the fog rolled in.

It wasn't a visual fog. It was a sensory one.

The world lost its sharp edges. Colors became muted, pastel washes of grey and beige. Sounds were muffled, as if she were underwater.

Alice's voice, usually sharp and funny, became a drone.

"You okay, Em? You're staring at the wall again."

"I'm fine," Emily said.

But her voice sounded wrong. Slow. Thick.

Her tongue felt huge in her mouth. A slab of meat she couldn't control.

Slurring, Dr. Vogel had said. *A temporary side effect. Ataxia. Difficulty with muscle coordination.*

She tried to stand up. Her legs felt heavy, like she was wading through molasses.

She stumbled.

"Whoa," Alice said, catching her. "Easy there, space cadet."

"I'm fine," Emily repeated. It was the only sentence she could form.

She went to the cafeteria for lunch.

The smell hit her at the door.

Usually, the cafeteria smelled of floor wax and pizza.

Today, it smelled of... slaughter.

The scent of the meatloaf was overpowering. It smelled of raw blood. Of guts. Of something dead that had been left in the sun.

Emily gagged.

She walked to the line. She grabbed a tray. Her hands were shaking.

Tremors, Vogel had said. *Benign.*

She looked at the food.

The mashed potatoes looked like grey paste. The green beans looked like worms.

And the meat...

It was pulsing.

Just a little. A rhythmic throb. *Thump. Thump.*

Emily stared at it.

"Eat," a voice whispered.

It wasn't the lunch lady.

It was the voice.

"Eat the flesh. Take it into you."

Emily dropped the tray.

CLANG.

The sound echoed in the cavernous room. Silence rippled out from the crash site.

Everyone looked at her. Hundreds of eyes.

"I'm sorry," Emily whispered. "I'm sorry."

She ran.

She ran out of the cafeteria, ignoring the stares, ignoring the whispers.

She's crazy. That's the girl who freaked out in the library. She's on drugs.

Yes, Emily thought. *I am on drugs. And they aren't working.*

She went to her class. *Introduction to Anthropology.*

She sat in the back row.

Professor Arndt was talking about shamanism. About possession cults in Haiti.

"In these cultures," Arndt said, pacing the stage, "the possessed individual is not seen as sick. They are seen as a vessel. A horse for the spirits to ride."

Emily gripped her desk.

A horse.

That's what she felt like. A beast of burden. Being ridden by something heavy and cruel.

The Gambrolie made her body heavy, but it didn't stop the rider. It just made the horse too tired to buck.

The rider was digging its spurs in.

She felt a pain in her side. Sharp. Hot.

She looked down.

She was digging her pen into her hand. The ink was bleeding into her skin, mixing with blood.

She hadn't even felt it.

She stopped.

She looked up at the professor.

Professor Arndt had stopped talking. He was looking at her.

But his face...

His face was melting.

His eyes were sliding down his cheeks. His mouth was a vertical slit.

He opened his mouth to speak.

But instead of words, a swarm of flies flew out.

Buzzing.

The sound filled the room.

Emily stood up.

"Stop it!" she screamed. "Stop looking at me!"

The class turned.

They didn't have faces.

They were mannequins. Blank, smooth plastic heads.

And they were all laughing.

A dry, scratching sound.

Emily grabbed her bag and ran.

She ran to the park. The shortcut.

It was snowing. Big, wet flakes that stuck to her eyelashes.

She sat on a bench, shivering.

She looked at the bottle of pills in her hand.

Gambrolic.

Dr. Vogel said it would fix the wires. He said it would stop the storm.

But the storm was inside the pill.

The pill locked the doors. It boarded up the windows.

But it locked the monster *inside* with her.

She couldn't pray.

She tried.

"Our Father..."

Her mind went blank. The words were gone. Erased.

We ate them, the voice whispered. *We ate your prayers.*

You are empty. You are a house swept clean.

And we are moving in.

A dog trotted by. A stray mongrel.

It stopped. It looked at her.

It whined.

Then it snarled.

It bared its teeth, backing away, its hackles raised.

It wasn't looking at Emily.

It was looking at the thing sitting on the bench next to her.

Emily didn't want to look.

But she had to.

She turned her head.

The bench was empty.

But the snow...

The snow on the empty seat was depressed.

A perfect imprint of a large, heavy body.

And the smell...

Sulfur. And burning hair.

The thing was sitting right next to her.

Waiting.

"You are tired," it whispered. *"Sleep. Let us take the wheel."*

Emily closed her eyes.

She felt a hand on her shoulder.

A cold, heavy hand.

She didn't fight it.

She was too tired. The Gambrolic made her so tired.

She leaned into the cold.

And let the darkness take her.